Housing Units, Rentals, and Short-Term Rentals in Brunswick, Maine

Summary of data assembly and validation

October 2026

Abstract

This report puts together the public records needed to count Brunswick's housing stock and identify its rental and short-term rental (STR) units. It draws on four sources: the town's April 2025 STR listings report, U.S. Census Bureau estimates, the Town of Brunswick's parcel-level assessing data, and town, state, and press reports used to check the results. The assessing data yields a unit-level database of 10,483 housing units: 5,539 single-family homes, 1,401 mobile homes, and 2,683 rental units that can be identified from the records. Checks against outside sources show the database is close to complete. The one systematic error is in the largest apartment complexes, where the assessor's unit counts are far too low. With that corrected, the database totals about 10,680 units (excluding assisted living) and about 3,200 rental units. Both figures match the 2020 Census plus new construction and the town's own estimate of roughly 3,000 rental units.

1 Data sources

Source	What it provides	Used for
STR listings report (Excel, April 18, 2025)	439 STR listings from the town's compliance monitoring, with address, parcel number, platform, and whether each meets the town's STR definition	STR locations
American Community Survey (ACS) 2020–2024 5-year	Town-level estimates of housing units, structure type, tenure, and vacancy, with margins of error	Benchmark totals
2020 Decennial Census (PL 94-171)	Housing unit count for 2020	Benchmark total
Town of Brunswick *Parcels With Assessing Data* (ArcGIS, updated Sept. 1, 2026)	All 10,084 assessing accounts: land use, unit count, building style, owner, mailing address, exemptions, year built, value, parcel shape	Unit-level database
Census TIGER/Line 2023	Town boundary, roads, water	Map
Town, state, and press reports (see References)	Rental registry estimates, subsidized housing inventory, new construction, unit counts for named complexes	Validation

2 Short-term rental listings

The town's STR report (one sheet, 439 rows, 24 columns) was converted to `RentalListings2025-04-18.csv`. Parcel numbers were kept as text so their leading zeros are preserved.

- 207 listings (47%) have no address, and 196 of those also have no parcel number. Of the 207, 198 meet the STR definition, so most STRs in the report cannot be located.
- The 232 listings with addresses cover 142 distinct addresses, since one unit is often listed on several platforms. The Census Geocoder placed 137 of these and OpenStreetMap placed 4 more, for 141 of 142.
- After removing duplicate listings, there are 147 distinct STR units with addresses that meet the STR definition, and 146 of them are mapped.
- Joining on parcel number, 129 of the 137 listed parcels match a housing record; the other 8 are hotels, motels, inns, or a store. Of the matched parcels, 73 have an owner-occupant on site, either a homestead-exempt home or an owner living in one unit of a multi-unit building.

3 Census estimates

Table 1 gives ACS 2020–2024 5-year estimates for "Brunswick town, Cumberland County," pulled with the R package `tidycensus`.

Table 1: ACS 2020–2024 estimates, Brunswick town (90% margins of error).

Measure	Estimate	± MOE	Share
Total housing units	9,523	362	100%
Single-family, detached	4,985	341	52%
Single-family, detached + attached	5,885	386	62%
Mobile homes	1,197	207	13%
Rental units (renter-occupied + vacant for rent + rented, not occupied)	2,566	310	27%
of which single-family	529	144	6%
Owner-occupied units	6,347	367	67%
Vacant, seasonal/recreational use	165	90	2%

The 2020 Census counted 9,966 housing units, about 440 more than the ACS estimate. The ACS reports 0 (±20) vacant units for rent, so its rental figure equals renter-occupied units.

4 Unit-level housing database

4.1 Method

The town's parcel layer was downloaded in full. Each record is an assessing account: a parcel, or a condo unit or mobile home that shares a parcel with others.

Housing records. Records are kept as housing if the land use code is residential (single-family, single-family with apartment, condo/PUD, mobile home on own land or in a park, 2-unit, 3-unit, 4–7 unit, 8+ unit, boarding house, senior/assisted living), or if the building style is an apartment building on otherwise non-residential land. The second group is mostly tax-exempt owners such as

the Greater Brunswick Housing Corporation, Bowdoin College, and Tedford Housing. Buildings with commercial space on the ground floor and apartments above ("Com/Apt") are included, with one unit assumed to be commercial. Dormitories and offices are excluded; dormitories are group quarters in Census terms.

Unit counts. Units come from the assessor's occupancy field. Single-family homes, condos, and mobile homes count as one unit each; a single-family home with an apartment counts as at least two. Sections 6 and 6.1 describe the corrections for large complexes.

Tenure. Maine's homestead exemption requires the owner to live in the home as a permanent residence, so a homestead exemption marks an owner-occupied unit. A record with no exemption is also treated as owner-occupied if the tax bill goes to the property's own address.

- In a multi-unit building, every unit except an owner-occupant's own unit counts as a rental.
- Apartments owned by tax-exempt organizations, and senior/assisted living, count as rentals.
- A single unit with no owner-occupant is *unclear*: it could be a long-term rental, an STR, a second home, or vacant. The records cannot tell these apart. Units linked to an STR listing that meets the definition are labeled as STRs.

4.2 Results

Table 2: Housing units by building type and tenure (assessing data as of Sept. 1, 2026, with the corrections in Section 6.1).

Building type	Owner-occ.	Rental	STR	Unclear	Total
Single-family	4,412	–	36	724	5,172
Single-family with apartment	149	218	–	–	367
Condo / PUD unit	775	–	1	166	942
Mobile home in park	1,096	–	–	83	1,179
Mobile home on own land	174	–	–	48	222
2-unit	61	287	–	–	348
3–4 unit	26	424	–	–	450
5+ unit	3	892	–	–	895
Apartments, tax-exempt owner	–	352	–	–	352
Mixed-use commercial/apartment	12	165	–	34	211
Senior/assisted living	–	339	–	–	339
Boarding house	–	6	–	–	6
Total	6,708	2,683	37	1,055	10,483

Of the 1,055 unclear units, the owner's mailing address is in Brunswick for 375, elsewhere in Maine for 335, and out of state for 343. Owners mailing from out of state are more likely to have second homes or STRs.

5 Map

Figure 1 shows rental units, sized by the number of rental units at each parcel, and the 146 mapped STR units, with an enlarged panel for downtown and Bowdoin. Rentals concentrate downtown,

around Bowdoin, along Pleasant Street, and at Brunswick Landing and Cook's Corner. STRs concentrate downtown and along the coastal peninsulas (Mere Point, Harpswell Neck, Middle Bay).

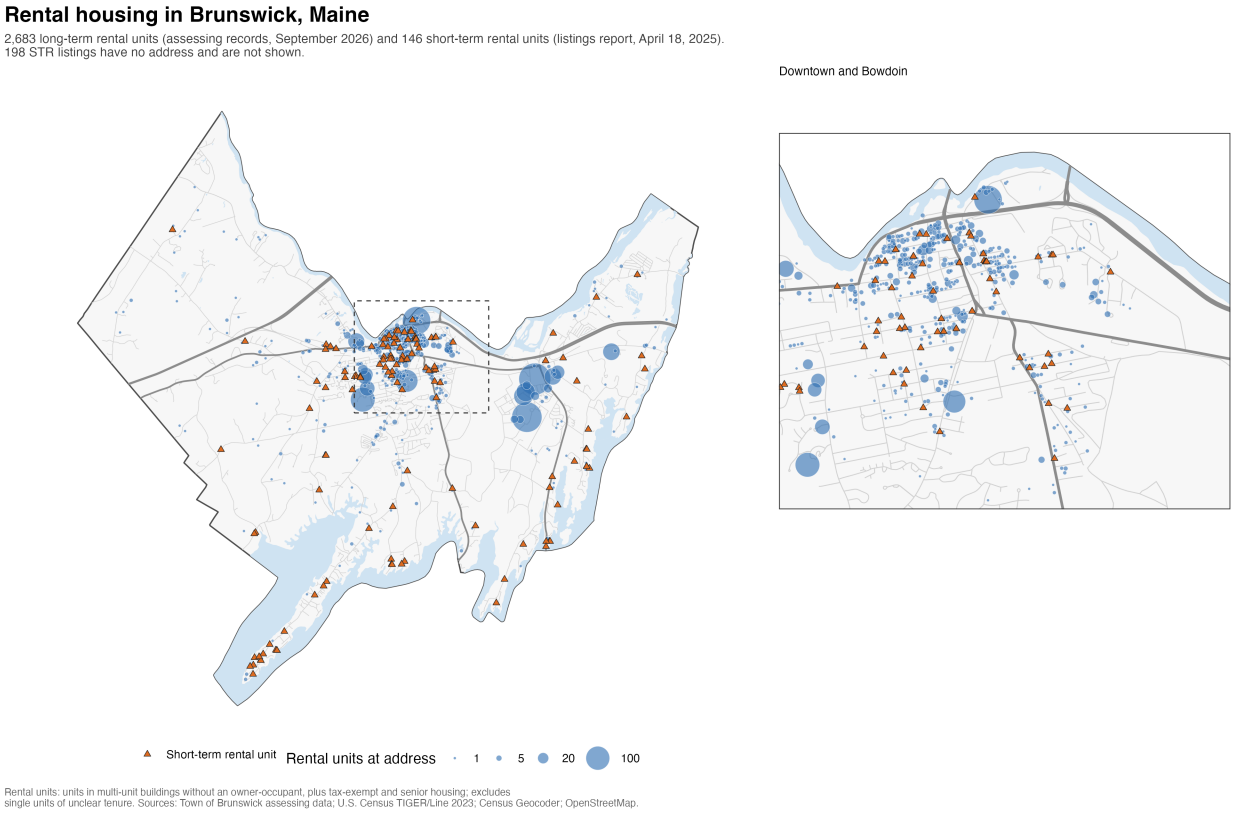


Figure 1: Rental housing and short-term rentals in Brunswick. The 198 STR listings without an address are not shown. Single units of unclear tenure are not shown as rentals.

6 Validation against town and state reports

Table 3 compares the database with every outside count found for Brunswick. The largest discrepancy, the undercounting of large apartment complexes, is described in Section 6.1; the gaps that remain are listed in Section 6.2.

6.1 Undercounting of large complexes

On commercial assessment cards, which cover most large apartment complexes, the occupancy field is often far below the real number of units. It may be recording buildings rather than apartments. For example, Atlantic Pointe Phase 1 has a $36 million building assessed with "16" units but actually has 181. Two steps address this:

1. **Corrected from outside sources** (`data/unit_overrides.csv`): Atlantic Pointe Phase 1 (10 Townsend Ln, 181 units), Atlantic Pointe Phase 2 (8 Admiral Harry Rich Dr, 64 units), and Perryman Village (51 Perryman Dr, 50 units).
2. **Flagged as likely undercounts**: apartment-only commercial records with at least $2 million in building value, where dividing assessed building value by a benchmark per-unit value gives

Table 3: Database compared with outside sources.

Check	Source	Their figure	Database	Verdict
Total units	2020 Census + new construction since	≈ 10,500	10,144 recorded; ≈10,680 corrected (excl. assisted living)	Complete within 1–2% once corrected
Rental units	Council estimate during the 2025 rental registry debate	≈3,000 units in 683 buildings	2,683 on 604 parcels; ≈3,220 corrected	Consistent
Renter households	ACS 2020–24	2,566 ± 310	2,683–3,220	Consistent; ACS is a 5-year average and misses the newest buildings
Mobile homes	ACS 2020–24	1,197 ± 207	1,401	Higher, but every record has an assessed home; ACS is known to undercount mobile homes
Built 2010–2023	Comprehensive Plan (Assessing Dept.)	MH 322; condo 96; 4+ unit 290; single-family 870	318; 79; ≈300; 529	Matches, except single-family (see Section 6.2)
Subsidized housing	Comprehensive Plan; Brunswick Housing Authority; listing sites	Perryman Village, Creekside Village, Riverside Estates, Woodlawn Tower, Pejepscot Terrace, Tedford	All found	Perryman was recorded as 1 unit; corrected to 50
New complexes	Press coverage	Atlantic Pointe 181 + 64; Sandpiper 63	Found; Atlantic Pointe recorded as 16 + 16	Corrected
STRs	STR listings report; 2022 town assessing memo	439 listings (≈150 Airbnb listings in 2022)	146 units mapped; 198 STR listings without an address	About half can be placed

at least 1.5 times the recorded count. The benchmarks are $198k per unit for buildings from 2015 on (Sandpiper, 63 units; Atlantic Pointe Phase 1, 181 units) and $120k per unit for older buildings (Riverside Estates, 48 units). These records keep the assessor's count; the estimate is stored in `units_from_value`.

Adding the roughly 537 missing units brings both the total and the rental count in line with outside benchmarks, which suggests the adjustment is about the right size. The per-complex numbers are still estimates. Exact counts can be looked up by hand on the assessor's property cards or the complexes' own websites; the online cards block automated requests.

6.2 Remaining gaps

- **Single-family construction since 2010.** The Comprehensive Plan reports 870 single-family homes added from 2010 through about 2023; the database has 529 built in that period. This gap is unexplained. The plan's figure may be based on permits or may count homes in planned unit developments as single-family.
- **Unclear tenure.** 1,055 single units have neither a homestead exemption nor a tax bill sent to the property. Brunswick's rental registry, expanded to all rental units in April 2025, would settle these, but it is not public. The Fire Prevention Office or the Housing Committee could provide it.

Table 4: Records flagged as likely undercounts.

Address	Owner	Built	Recorded	Value-based estimate
121 Pegasus St	JSIP Pegasus Brunswick Landing	2002	10	109
20 Captains Way	Apartments at Brunswick Landing	2021	12	89
5 Midway Cir	JSIP BG MT Brunswick Landing	1980	2	81
126 Pegasus St	JSIP Pegasus Brunswick Landing	2002	10	74
1 Independence Dr	JSIP BG MT Brunswick Landing	1959	2	47
0 Parkview Circle	Northern New England Conference	1979	4	45
143 River Rd	On the Green Associates	1985	4	31
Pejepscot Terrace	United Pejepscot Housing	1980	8	30
0 Oakwood Terrace	Quercus Properties	1980	6	28
17 Wadsworth Rd	Wadsworth Place	1985	6	24
18 Coral Sea St	DC Landing 2	2023	12	23
20 Katherine St	Katherine Court	1987	6	22
4–5 Nimitz Dr	DC Landing 1	2023	12	20
19 Station Ave	WFF Brunswick Owner	2017	12	20
Total			106	643

- **Unaddressed STRs.** 198 STR listings that meet the definition have no address or parcel. They may overlap with each other (one unit listed on several platforms) and with the unclear-tenure units.
- **Pipeline.** The town's March 2026 housing data lists 771 units approved and 288 under review. These are not built and are not counted. The 200+ unit Bath Road project still appears as vacant land, which is consistent.
- **Bowdoin.** Dormitories are excluded on purpose. A few college-owned houses coded under school land use codes may be faculty housing and are also excluded.

7 Files

All files are in the project folder; every result can be regenerated by running the R scripts.

File	Contents
`RentalListings2025-04-18.csv`	STR listings report, converted from Excel
`brunswick_housing.R`	ACS estimates; writes `brunswick_housing_summary.csv`
`brunswick_housing_db.R`	Downloads the parcel data and builds the database
`data/brunswick_housing_units.csv`	One row per housing unit: building type, tenure, single-family and mobile-home flags
`data/brunswick_housing_parcels.csv`	One row per housing record: unit counts, tenure, owner, mailing address, year built, assessed value, last sale, STR listings, unit-count flags
`data/brunswick_housing.gpkg`	Parcel shapes for GIS use
`data/unit_overrides.csv`	Unit counts corrected from outside sources, with citations
`brunswick_map.R`, `brunswick_map.png`	Map of rental and STR units

References

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- Town of Brunswick Assessing Department, memo on short-term rentals (Nov. 2022). https://www.brunswickme.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_11142022-2772
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